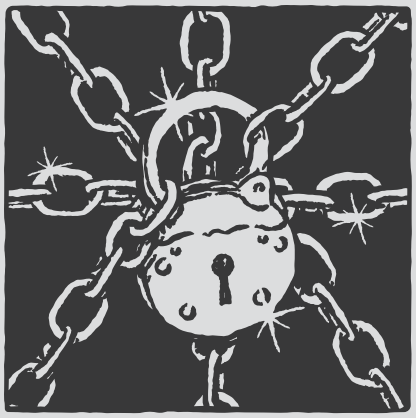


Secure in God's Love

Lesson 15 Questions

First Day: Read the Lesson 14 Notes.

The notes and lecture fortify the truth of the passage for understanding and application to daily life.

1. How did the lecture impact how you view the suffering you face?

2. What points in the notes offered you hope for today and the future?

Second Day: Read Romans 8:28.

Paul revealed a great promise.

3. What did Paul say believers know, and what did he mean by "all things"?

4. a. Write verse 28 in your own words. Share any assurances that arise within you as you write.

   b. What attributes of God are revealed in this verse? How does this comfort or challenge you?

5. a. How have you seen God's truth in Romans 8:28 come to pass in life's struggles?

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b. When has God's good been different than the good you hoped for, and how might you pray when God's good feels hard to find?

Third Day: Read Romans 8:29-30.

Paul offered understanding regarding God's sovereign purpose for His people.

6. a. Briefly explain the following concepts. (For help, see Matthew 11:28-30; John 6:37, 44; 10:1-5; 11:25-44; Romans 1:6-7; 3:22-26; 8:17-21; Ephesians 1:4-5, 11; or other Bible passages.)

   Foreknew

   Predestined

   Called

   Justified

   Glorified

   b. What do verses 29-30 reveal about God, and why is this good news?

7. a. What are some ways God works to conform His people to the image of His Son? (See also Romans 5:3-5; Ephesians 4:22-24; Philippians 2:13; 2 Timothy 3:12, 15-17; Hebrews 2:18; 5:7-8; 1 Peter 1:6-7; or other Bible passages.)

   b. What might stand in the way of professing believers exhibiting Christlikeness in their daily lives?

8. How do you know God is at work in your life, making you more like Jesus?

Fourth Day: Read Romans 8:31-35.

Paul offered questions and answers regarding the spiritual benefits God's people experience through faith.

9. a. List the questions and answers given in verses 31-35. (See also verses 36-39.)

   b. What conclusions can be made based on what Paul wrote?

10. How do Paul's questions and answers challenge or encourage you?

Fifth Day: Read Romans 8:35-39.

Paul proclaimed nothing could separate God's people from His love.

11. Why might Paul have quoted Psalm 44:22 in answer to the question in verse 35? (See also John 16:33.)

12. a. How do "all these things" listed in verses 35-37 relate to "all things" in verses 28 and 32?

    b. In verse 37, what words did Paul use to describe believers, and who makes this possible?

13. Of what was Paul convinced in verses 38-39, and why?

14. List troubles, concerns, opposition, and fears that are present in your life today. Rewrite verses 38-39 as your statement of certain confidence in God's love for you in Christ Jesus your Lord.

Sixth Day: Review Romans 8:28-39.

God's people rest securely in His good purposes, salvation, and love.

15. What have you learned from this passage about your security in Christ, and how will you thank Him?

Homiletics for Group and Administrative Leaders: Romans 8:28-39

Next step: Continue this lesson with group discussion, lecture, and notes.

Lecture Notes

Lesson 15 Notes

Romans 8:28-39

Focus Verse

"He who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all—how will he not also, along with him, graciously give us all things?" (Romans 8:32)

Outline

- God's Promise – Romans 8:28
- God's Purpose – Romans 8:29-30
- God's Protection – Romans 8:31-39

Engage

Life's troubles can be unsettling. Relational challenges, health concerns, work problems, and financial difficulties surface and create uncertainties that threaten our peace. When life becomes unstable, external stresses and internal struggles can also affect our physical bodies. Where can we find rest and assurance? **Paul invited his readers to consider their ultimate security: God alone offers perfect peace.** His good character accomplishes eternal good in the lives of His people.

As Paul explained the depth and breadth of God's love, he revealed that God, in His goodness, works all things for the good of His people. God's grip upon His people is so strong that they cannot be separated from Him. Paul offered tremendous encouragement to believers who experienced life in ancient Rome's trenches of depravity. Paul's words pour forth the same encouragement to afflicted believers today. **God's people rest securely in His good purposes, salvation, and love.**

God's Promise – Romans 8:28

Experiences across generations show that God's people have never been exempt from life's difficulties. In Romans 8:18-27, Paul affirmed that believers' suffering can never outweigh the future glory God promises. Though circumstances often promise the worst, God's promise in Romans 8:28 offers resounding hope. **Paul declared, "And we know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose."** This tremendous truth reaches to all believers in every situation—all for God's glory.

Pondering the Promise

Paul opened God's spectacular promise with the words, "And we know." What believers know and believe fuels how they live. God's promise remains certain, even when we do not feel or

see the good outcome He promises. God works in all things, even the worst evil, and will bring eternal good to His people through every suffering, tragedy, and joy. Paul suffered greatly,[1] yet his confidence in Scripture and faith in Christ assured him of God's work on his behalf.[2] The Holy Spirit inspired Paul to write this truth so we too can know God works for the good of His people.

God placed no boundaries on this promise; Paul declared God's work in all things. Sometimes we see God bring obvious victory. God also works through life's darkest moments and seemingly hopeless circumstances to accomplish His ultimate good. Our situation itself may not be good, but God's presence and comfort rise even when relief does not. At Christ's cross and grave, God worked through the worst evil to accomplish the greatest good.[3] Times of suffering offer opportunities to glorify God as we trust Him. Even death cannot leave lasting wounds.[4] God's promise lasts for eternity. In all things, God works for good.

What exactly did Paul mean by the word "good"? God's good does not guarantee health, wealth, or comfortable living. **God's greatest good for His people on earth is to make them more like Jesus Christ in this life[5] and in heaven's glory.[6]** God promises and secures His good for His children. While on earth, believers experience joy, peace, and the beauties of family and friendships. They also endure sin, sickness, and every other kind of suffering. Life in this world can involve one evil encounter and setback after another. We encounter betrayal, not faithfulness. Hating others is not love. Persecution is not protection. Death is not life. But God brings lasting good even through this world's fallenness. He uses all things to achieve His good for His people.

Paul made it clear Romans 8:28 only applies to those who love God—to believers in Jesus Christ. After all, how can all things work for good for those who reject God, who gives all things?[7] But for those who live in Christ by grace through faith, God works in every situation for their good. He called them according to His purpose, and His plan will be accomplished through them.

God's Purpose – Romans 8:29-30

The certainty of God's promise to make all things good rests with Him. In these verses, Paul spoke exclusively of God and His actions without mentioning human involvement. God Himself accomplishes His good purpose. Paul's continued explanation revealed that God will see each of His people safely through this life and into His presence for all eternity. Not one believer will be lost.[8]

Assurance for God's People – 8:29

In writing about God's secure hold on believers, Paul pointed to five timeless truths about God. God foreknew, predestined, called, justified, and glorified the saved. These truths flow from eternity past to eternity future. The words connect as an unbreakable chain, with five golden links describing God's wonder, beauty, and activity in salvation.

1. **Paul's suffering:** Acts 14:19-20; 16:22-24; 21:30-32; 22:22-28; 2 Corinthians 11:23-28
2. **God's purposes:** Genesis 50:20
3. **Greatest good:** Acts 2:23-24
4. **Beyond death:** Daniel 3:16-18; John 11:25-26; 1 Corinthians 15:54-55; Revelation 21:4
5. **Christlike character:** Galatians 5:22-23; Philippians 2:1-8; Colossians 3:12-17
6. **Glory:** Philippians 3:20-21; 1 John 3:2-3
7. **Giver of all things:** James 1:17
8. **No believer lost:** John 10:27-30

What did Paul mean when he used the word "foreknew"? Some say that because God knows all things, He knows beforehand what people will do—who will and will not believe. In other words, God looks into the future and sees the eventual faith of those who believe. Others look to the Greek word *proginosko,* which can mean to choose something or someone beforehand. When foreknowledge involves people, the word can mean special favor granted to a special relationship. The Old Testament often speaks of God's foreknowledge in this intensely personal and loving way.[9] Recognizing God's foreknowledge turns our attention from ourselves to Him. Salvation begins with God,[10] who lovingly chose to conform sinful, undeserving people to be like Jesus. **God's foreknowledge demonstrates that every link in salvation's chain began by God's grace in eternity past.[11]**

The word "predestined" flows from God's deep and personal love. This differs greatly from fatalism, which is impersonal and excludes God, saying, "What will be, will be." Fatalism implies no human responsibility or dignity. Paul used the term "predestined" to express that God fixed His love on His people before the world began. Believers' destinies are wrapped in God's loving choice to make them like His Son so "that he [Jesus] might be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters." God predestines believers to accomplish His purpose.[12]

God's love in extending His call displays true grace for humanity, which Jesus proved with arms opened wide upon the cross.

Eternity Past, Present, and Future – 8:30

The next link in salvation's chain is the word "called." The Bible speaks of two different calls. First, a general call invites everyone everywhere to repent of sin, turn to Jesus, and be saved. Jesus gave this type of call when He said, "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest"[13] and "Let anyone who is thirsty come to me and drink."[14] This call remains open to all people. But left to themselves, people do not come. Sinful pride and rebellion lead people to prefer their own way. This is why Jesus also said, "No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws them."[15]

The other type of call is the specific inward call from God, the third link in salvation's chain. Jesus demonstrated this call when He raised Lazarus.[16] Physically, Lazarus was what all people are spiritually by nature—dead and without the desire or ability to respond. Jesus called Lazarus specifically, by name. No one else in the tomb responded. Lazarus alone heard Jesus's call and supernaturally obeyed. With the same effective power, God calls people from death to life today. **Not one person deserves God's amazing grace, but He chose to ground His call in what He foreknew and predestined, which would cost the life of His sinless Son.** God's love in extending His call displays true grace for humanity, which Jesus proved with arms opened wide upon the cross.

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9. **God's foreknowledge:** Genesis 18:19; Jeremiah 1:5; Amos 3:2
10. **Salvation:** John 1:12-13
11. **Eternity past:** 1 Peter 1:20-21; Revelation 13:8
12. **Created for God's work:** Ephesians 2:10
13. **Rest:** Matthew 11:28
14. **Thirsty:** John 7:37
15. **Drawn by Father:** John 6:44
16. **Lazarus:** John 11:25-26, 38-44

God's calling connects what God determined beforehand with what passes over into time. God exists outside of time. His eternal knowledge and determination intersect with human experience. **God's call is the point where what He decreed in eternity about His loved ones becomes a fact in time-bound lives.** At a specific point in time, God personally and individually saves people through His call to faith.

Following "called" on salvation's chain is "justified." God, as judge, declared His people, though sinners, to be in right standing before Him.[17] This declaration cannot be based on human merit, which no one can offer. Rather, God justifies people on Jesus's all-sufficient merit. Jesus took sin's full penalty at the cross, and God credits His Son's perfect righteousness to all who believe in Him.[18]

Justification follows calling because God's call is what brings faith into being. Faith rises as the first true evidence of the spiritual life God's call produces. Without faith, there is no justification. God saves people by or through faith, not because of faith. Paul later explained that faith comes by hearing the Word of God.[19] God graciously uses His Word to create faith within believers' hearts to bring His gift of justification to them.

The final link in salvation's chain is "glorified," which means to be made to be like Jesus Christ.[20] Surprisingly, Paul referred to "glorified" in the past tense, as already accomplished. Yet we can easily see that glorification remains future. How could Paul refer to glorification as already completed? This is possible only because God's purpose is so certain that believers are already safe and secure for eternity in Him.[21] When turning our eyes from earthly living to Jesus seated at the Father's right hand, believers see themselves already glorified through identification with Him.[22] Paul's words exemplify how prophets spoke about certain future events as if they were already accomplished.[23] Paul deliberately assured his readers that God will glorify even the weakest believer. God never changes His mind. His Word remains certain and true.[24]

Because God initiated salvation, we can know He will continue His work until the day He makes believers fully like Jesus Christ.[25] **Believers can expect that they will be glorified—illumined with God's glory for God's glory.**

God's Protection – Romans 8:31-39

Romans 8 concludes with words that crest the highest peaks of scriptural truth with breathtaking beauty. The question, "If God is for us, who can be against us?" resonates with strength beyond compare. The truth that nothing can separate us from the love of God emanates enduring hope and hits a forceful crescendo that still rings today. **God's protection of His people on earth and in heaven remains undeniable, unstoppable, and astoundingly unbreakable.**

17. **Declared righteous:** Romans 3:21-31
18. **Perfect righteousness:** 2 Corinthians 5:21
19. **Faith by hearing:** Romans 10:17
20. **Made like Christ:** Romans 8:18-27; 2 Corinthians 3:18; Philippians 3:20-21
21. **Safe in eternity:** Ephesians 2:6; Colossians 3:3-4
22. **Already glorified:** Ephesians 1:3-4
23. **Prophetic past:** Isaiah 44:28; 52:14; 53:1-6
24. **Unchanging and true:** Numbers 23:19; Psalm 33:11; Malachi 3:6; Titus 1:2; Hebrews 6:18
25. **Completed work:** Philippians 1:6

Safe and Secure

The Doctrine of Eternal Security

Believers are promised sure and certain security in Christ. When a person believes in Jesus Christ, condemnation has no hold over them. Paul said, "It is God who justifies. Who then is the one who condemns? No one." Having accomplished believers' salvation, Jesus is now at God's right hand, interceding for believers. **Salvation does not depend on human strength or faithfulness; salvation comes through Christ and His completed work on the cross.** By faith, the Holy Spirit seals and indwells for eternity everyone who believes.[1] Paul wrote, "He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus."[2] Salvation is God's work from beginning until glorious, eternal consummation.

Paul later explained and celebrated that nothing can separate God's people from Him or His love. No person, principality, supernatural force, personal failure, or anything else can come between God and His people. Moses lacked trust and acted independently. David sinned grievously. Peter denied Jesus. Paul suffered greatly. Scripture includes many examples of human and supernatural forces attempting to separate God from His people. But God's immovable and unwavering strength means nothing can thwart Him. He keeps His every promise. So when His Word says, "Neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God," He means it. Believers experience confidence, freedom, joy, and purpose in God's firm and loving grip—in this life and for eternity.

The supposed protection this world seeks, such as a financial safety net or a home security system, will never provide the eternal security Christ offers. In fact, those who reject faith in Christ will never find the refuge they crave. With their very lives in jeopardy, people are tragically lulled through wrong thinking into considering their sins insignificant and failing to understand they need a Savior. Missing out on God's great promise of eternal life and eternal security in Jesus, who gave His life on humanity's behalf, is a loss beyond description.

Those who believe in Christ, their Savior, are truly saved. They are immediately blessed as part of God's family and rest securely in their eternal salvation; enduring hope is theirs. While people saved from sin's penalty still struggle with sin, the Holy Spirit gives them a new nature and sanctifies them, leading them to grow to be more like Christ.[3] Clinging to God's Word, believers who realize that nothing and no one can ever snatch them from their Father's hands overflow with delight. They live freely, loving God, joyfully serving Him, and gladly sharing Christ and His good news with others.

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1. **Sealed:** John 10:27-30; Ephesians 1:13-14
2. **God's work completed:** Philippians 1:6
3. **Growing in Christlikeness:** Romans 5:1-5; 6:1-23; 7:4-6; 8:5-17

Paul's Questions – 8:31-34

Paul presented a series of questions that celebrate God's grand love for His people. Each question argues not only God's love but also His power and certain hold upon His people. Paul's journey of praise in these verses brings sweet assurance to the hearts of all believers.

Paul opened verse 31 with a precursory question, "What, then, shall we say in response to these things?" As Paul approached His triumphant exclamations, perhaps he intended to capture all he had written from Chapter 5 forward. Paul continued with, "If God is for us, who can be against us?" This question might at first seem confusing. Many people and things oppose God and His children. The world, our sinful flesh, and God's greatest enemy, Satan, create constant opposition in a believer's life.[26] While many are hostile toward God's people, the One who is for them is greater. No person, sin, or supernatural entity can get past the God who is for us.

Paul moved his argument of triumph forward in verse 32 by asking, "He who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for us all—how will he not also, along with him, graciously give us all things?" God is the good Father of a forever family. God gave His greatest gift—Jesus, His only Son. He did not spare His Son from pain and death. A faithful promise-keeper, God sealed all of His promises in Jesus's blood, which secures every promise He has made. Paul used the Greek verb *paredoken,* translated as "gave over," to point to God's gracious purpose. God lovingly gave His sinless Son over to death to rescue sinners from their deserved judgment. Life and righteousness come to believers through Jesus.

A faithful promise-keeper, God sealed all of His promises in Jesus's blood, which secures every promise He has made.

Paul's third question moved into the legal realm of a court of law. Can believers' struggle with post-conversion sin undo salvation? Does any accusation exist that can cause God to condemn a believer in Christ? Many believers find it hard to understand what justification means to them personally. God has declared every believer eternally righteous in Christ through faith in Christ's once-for-all payment for sin. Believers stand before God not in their imperfect righteousness but as new creations clothed in Christ's righteousness, which never changes, fades, or fails.

The prophet Zechariah saw a vision demonstrating the meaning of standing justified before God.[27] Zechariah saw Joshua the high priest appear before the angel of the Lord in filthy clothes, depicting Joshua's sinfulness. Satan eagerly accused Joshua,[28] but the Lord rebuked him. He ordered Joshua's filthy clothes to be removed and replaced with fine, clean garments. He took away Joshua's sin. Who could accuse Joshua now? No one! God had already clothed Joshua in righteousness that securely covered his past, present, and future. Joshua's story becomes our story through faith in Christ. **Apart from Christ, many could successfully condemn us. But because believers are in Christ, they cannot[29] because "it is God who justifies."** No one can stand against God.

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26. Constant opposition: Galatians 5:17; James 4:4; 1 Peter 5:8
27. Justified: Zechariah 3:1-7
28. The accuser: Revelation 12:10
29. Condemnation: 1 John 3:20

Paul's next question logically follows. Because the highest court possible has declared believers righteous in Christ, "Who then is the one who condemns?" **No one can condemn believers because Jesus Himself, who died and was raised to life, sits at God's right hand, interceding on their behalf.** Jesus will judge the world at His return.[30] In other words, because the judge Himself intercedes for believers, no accusation will get past Him. Christ freed believers once and for all when He died in their place on the cross.

Paul's Confidence – 8:35-39

Paul expressed great confidence in God and His unbridled love when he asked, "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or hardship or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword?" Having endured each of these trials, Paul could personally verify that none—not one—separated him from the Savior who loved him. Instead, Paul firmly testified to Jesus's love. In addition to personal experience, Paul offered God's Word as further proof. He quoted Psalm 44:22, which says, "For your sake we face death all day long; we are considered as sheep to be slaughtered." The Bible makes it clear that believers face danger and death. They endure great afflictions that sometimes feel impossible to bear. Real suffering causes far-reaching and deeply abiding physical, spiritual, emotional, and mental pain. **How comforting to know that not even this world's worst attempts can separate us from Christ's love.** Paul eloquently argued that in all things "we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us." Jesus is our certain comfort and sure strength in times of deep suffering.

As his personal testimony continued, Paul recorded his convictions with tenacious passion. Considering all creation, he confidently concluded, "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord." Paul dismissed every possible source that could separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus. Jesus came to earth, lived a perfect life, and died an excruciating death—all on behalf of sinful humanity. Now that He is raised from the dead, we await His promised return. Jesus will never give up on His people. There is no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus, and nothing can separate believers from God's love. Everyone who believes in the Lord Jesus Christ remains secure forever in God's love. **God's people rest securely in His good purposes, salvation, and love.**

Take to Heart

Hold Fast

God's great promise to work in all things "for the good of those who love him, who have been called according to his purpose" extends from the past to eternity. Our plans may seem good, but God has something even better in mind—making us like Christ.[31] Nothing can defeat the plans of our sovereign and all-powerful God. He orders absolutely all things, places, and people for the good of those who love Him. God's people live in utmost security because in Him all things are inevitably and completely for their good forever.

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30. Judgment: Romans 2:16
31. God's plans: Proverbs 19:21

Paul offered evidence for this extraordinary promise. Paul set forth the great truths about God's work in His unbreakable chain of salvation, proving just how secure God's people are in this world and for all eternity. God's love is unchangeable, personal, purposeful, and all-powerful. **His love is the strongest, steadiest, firmest, most substantial, unbending, constant, steady, and dependable reality.** His love is so sure that nothing in heaven or on earth can separate God's people from His love that is ours in Christ.

Apply It

"We know that in all things God works for the good of those who love him." God's promises are easy to trust when work, health, and relationships are steady. But what about when tragedy strikes? We struggle greatly to find God's good in times of deep suffering. Paul knew this firsthand. Much to our surprise, God may exchange the ease we seek for something difficult. Christians must be careful not to wield Romans 8:28 as a quick-fix salve when trying to console someone who is suffering. Anguish should never be easily dismissed. While suffering is woven into God's sovereign plan of salvation, we need gentle care in our suffering and to comfort others likewise in theirs. **God calls His people to give a clear, authentic, and compelling testimony of their faith in Jesus Christ, regardless of circumstances.** Whatever your current situation, God's purposes for you remain unchanged, and His glory is assured. What questions remain in your heart and mind regarding God's promise? Will you ask God to help you trust Him and obediently cling to Him, depending on His strength to get you through?

How willing are you to trust God with words like "foreknew" and "predestined"? God is sovereign, all-knowing, ever-present, and all-powerful. He knew you before you met Him. Maybe reading these notes is your first introduction to God. He knew you before today and planned that you would meet Him in His Word today. Whoever you are, right now, God speaks to you. Do you believe that God has known you from the beginning and predestined you for heaven? If your answer is yes, have you answered His call? If not, God beckons you to come to Him. How will you answer? Salvation's unbreakable chain is but one prayer away.

Who can stand against God? No one! Are you outnumbered by people who mock God's Word or your beliefs? Paul presented great and unwavering confidence in God. Will you pray for opportunities to gently and respectfully display quiet but firm confidence in God?[32] Will you work for peace by displaying the fruits of Christ's righteousness?[33] Nothing and no one can defeat believers because God Himself defends them. He reigns in victory over sin, death, and the devil. **God's people remain safe and secure eternally through faith in Christ Jesus.**

How does God's strong salvation chain compare to what you depend upon to secure identity, experiences, and possessions? We must live wisely in the world. The sovereign security God promises in this passage remains firm for all eternity. Paul's words challenge believers to answer God's call to live in confident, obedient faith. God works in our lives for eternal good. This promise frees us to step out in faith and follow Him without reservation. Further, this promise gives great hope: God is for you. God does not condemn you. **Nothing can separate you from the love of God in Christ Jesus.** Nothing now. Nothing ever. The unbreakable chain of salvation links believers forever to God. What praise will you offer to God in return?

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32. Confidence: 1 Peter 3:15
33. Fruitfulness: Galatians 5:22-23

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